Transfer of Power from Consuls to Emperor

When Marius became Consul with the support of the *equites* (new rich or propertied class below the rank of Senatorial Class), he made an attempt to push through a land distribution bill in the Senate. This led to violence. The allies of Marius were killed. This resulted in a civil war between the followers of Marius and Sulla. After expelling Marius Sulla reigned for three years as a virtual dictator. He was killed and succeeded by Cinna and Catalina.

Slave Revolts

There were more slave revolts in Rome than in Greece. The revolt of Spartacus was the most famous. It began in 73 BC (BCE) involving about 70,000 slaves. The revolt threatened the power in Rome. Ultimately Spartacus was killed and the revolt crushed. 6,000 of the followers of Spartacus were executed.

Establishment of Principate

The civil wars over social issues ended only to be replaced by civil wars between Generals. Marius and Cinna against Sulla, Pompey against Julius Caesar, after Caesar's death Brutus and Cassius against Mark Antony and Octavian (Caesar's nephew) and finally Octavian against Mark Antony. The rich, old and new alike, felt that allowing Octavian, now called Augustus, to establish a de facto monarchy was the only way to re-establish political stability. The period starting from Augustus (27 BC (BCE)) is known as Principate. Augustus called himself Imperator, equivalent to the English word Emperor.


Augustus

Society under Principate

During the period of Principate, the imperial ruling class became far more prosperous than under the republic. The period witnessed a great influx of luxury goods such as silk, spices, and gems from the east. Cities were built on a grand scale, with temples, theatres, stadia and colosseum, gymnasia, aqueducts, baths and markets. The rich people distracted the attention of the poor by organizing games and contests in circuses, where the gladiators were forced to fight and kill each other.

The most distinguished writers of the **Augustan Age** brought glory to the empire. Pliny the Elder completed a voluminous encyclopaedia of "science." He called it *Natural History.*

Punic Wars and the Emergence of Imperial Roman Empire

As Rome was growing in Italy, Carthage was growing in power in north Africa. The Carthaginians were the descendants of the Phoenicians who excelled in seafaring and trade. Rome and Carthage united to drive out the Greeks. Thereafter Carthage took Sicily and threatened the very existence of the Roman state. The three wars fought between them are called **Punic Wars**. Carthage sent a general named Hannibal. He defeated the Roman army and made a great part of Italy a desert. Fabius, who led the Romans, did not give up. In the second Punic War, Fabius confronted Hannibal and defeated him in the Battle of Zama. Pursued by the Roman army, Hannibal ended his life by poisoning himself. The third Punic War was declared on the Carthaginians by Rome. After the defeat and destruction of the Carthage in this War, Rome emerged as an unrivalled power in the western world.


Hannibal

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